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The Third Term: How the NDC Can Do What It Has Never Done

The NDC has never won three elections in a row. After a 14–1 result it begins from the strongest position in its history: on a uniform swing, only a reverse larger than the record of 2026 would cost it its majority. Grenada's landslides, however, have a habit of turning.

BY GREG HOSTEN GRENADA, CARRIACOU AND PETITE MARTINIQUE, GRENADA

ST. GEORGE'S, GRENADA—When the results were declared on 6th November 2026, the National Democratic Congress had achieved something it had never managed since its founding in 1987: a second consecutive election victory. Its two earlier governments, under Nicholas Brathwaite from 1990 and Tillman Thomas from 2008, each lasted a single term.

"On a uniform swing, the NDC loses its majority only if 2030/31 goes worse for it than 2026 went for the NNP."
GREG HOSTEN

The question for the NDC now is whether it can go one step further. Only two parties in Grenada's history have won three general elections in succession: Sir Eric Gairy's GULP, and the NNP, which won in 1995, 1999 and 2003. When Dickon Mitchell took office in June 2022, he told the country that the NDC would spend the next 15 years transforming Grenada, Carriacou and Petite Martinique. Fifteen years is three terms, and this volume asks what securing the third would require.

THE STRONGEST START IN THE PARTY'S HISTORY

The NDC won 37,369 votes in 2026, 60.8 per cent of the votes cast, and 14 of the 15 seats. Its vote rose in every constituency, from 37 additional votes in St. George North West to 904 in the Prime Minister's own St. David, and every NDC member who defended a seat increased their majority.

On paper, the cushion is enormous. If the constituencies are ranked by the NNP's share of the two-party vote, the eighth seat the NNP would need for a majority is Carriacou and Petite Martinique, where it took 37.2 per cent; to win it, the NNP would need a uniform swing of 12.8 points. The swing against the NNP in 2026, the worst result in its history, was 10.3, and a full reversal of that swing would return four seats to the NNP, not seven.

In other words, if every constituency moves by the same amount, the NDC loses its majority only if 2030/31 goes worse for it than 2026 went for the NNP. That is the starting point for a third term, though it is not the whole story.

WHY A LANDSLIDE IS NOT A GUARANTEE

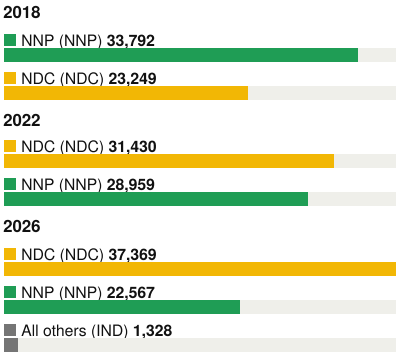
Grenada's recent history has been unkind to large majorities. The NNP won all 15 seats in 1999 and was reduced to a majority of one in 2003; the NDC won 11 of 15 in 2008 and lost every seat in 2013; and the NNP won all 15 in both 2013 and 2018, only to be out of office in 2022.

Three things went wrong for those governments, and they merit naming because they constitute the NDC's real risks. First, large majorities generate more ambition than a cabinet can satisfy: the 2008 NDC government was openly divided by 2012, with dissident MPs, Peter David among them, out of favour and the Prime Minister facing a motion of no confidence. Second, long-serving governments come to be judged on their record rather than their promises. Third, oppositions that are crushed tend to regroup, and they seldom repeat the same mistakes.

The 2026 result also carries a warning of its own. The NDC's vote amounted to 38.5 per cent of all registered voters; turnout fell to 63.3 per cent, and 35,571 registered voters did not vote at all, almost as many as voted NDC. The landslide rested as much on NNP supporters staying home as on new converts, and those voters can return.

2018 VS 2022 VS 2026

Votes by candidate, in party colours



12.8
Points of uniform swing the NNP needs to end the NDC majority

BY THE NUMBERS

14 of 15
Seats won in 2026, the NDC's best result ever

15 of 15
Constituencies where the NDC vote rose

12.8
Points of uniform swing needed to end the NDC majority

0
Times the NDC has won three elections in a row

THE NDC'S FRONT LINE

A third term will not be decided in St. David or St. George South, where the NDC took more than 70 per cent. It will be decided in a handful of seats that the NNP held in 2022 and lost narrowly in 2026.

Four seats would fall on a swing smaller than the one the NNP suffered in 2026. St. Andrew South East, where Education Minister David Andrew defeated the NNP leader by 162, requires a swing of 2.1 points; St. Andrew North East, won by 320, requires 4.0; St. Mark, won by 261, requires 4.6; and St. John, where Kerryne James won by 573, requires 6.4. Behind them sit St. Andrew North West (10.6), St. Patrick East (12.4) and Carriacou and Petite Martinique (12.8).

The Town of St. George is a special case. Claudette Joseph won with 1,269 votes against 730 for Mr. David's DPM and 536 for the NNP. Against a single opponent, the NNP would need a swing of 20 points; against a reunited opposition, the NDC was only three votes ahead. The Town is safe for the NDC only for as long as its opponents remain divided.

SEVEN THINGS THE NDC MUST DO

What follows is a strategy, not a prediction: the plan a disciplined governing party would derive from its own results.

1. TREAT THE MARGINALS AS IF THE ELECTION WERE NEXT YEAR

The four front-line seats need what the NDC gave them in opposition: a constant presence. Each member in a marginal seat should have a funded office, a full-time organiser and a household list built from the 2026 count. In St. Andrew South East the NNP leader lost only 44 votes between 2022 and 2026, and the NDC won by finding 351 new voters; it must continue to find them.

2. MANAGE FOURTEEN AMBITIONS

A government with 14 members of parliament has more backbenchers than it has ever had, and proportionately fewer of them can be ministers. This is the problem that broke the 2008 NDC government. The party needs visible work for every MP: constituency budgets, committee chairs, special envoy roles and clear rules for promotion. Earlier volumes of this series showed how ministerial office raised the profile of Andy Williams, Joseph Andall, Kerryne James and David Andrew in their own seats, and the same method must now reach the members outside the cabinet.

3. PUBLISH A REPORT CARD BEFORE THE OPPOSITION WRITES ONE

In 2022 the NDC promised a new hospital with teaching facilities, full implementation of the National Health Insurance scheme and more affordable housing. In July 2026 a NOW Grenada commentary argued that the government should present its report card before asking for a new list of promises. A government in its second term is judged on delivery, and the NDC should publish its own annual scorecard against the 2022 and 2026 manifestos, allowing the numbers to carry the argument.

4. ANSWER THE COST OF LIVING

The NNP's 2026 campaign asked voters whether they were better off, and offered to remove VAT on electricity and sugar, abolish the water levy and exempt tips from tax. It did not win them over in 2026, but in a third-term election, with the government's record on the ballot, the same questions will carry greater weight. The NDC needs a clear answer on prices, power bills and wages well before the writ.

5. SETTLE THE LEADERSHIP QUESTION EARLY

Grenada has no term limits. Mr. Mitchell has said that he personally supports them, but that his government does not plan to introduce them, because voters rejected term limits at referendum. That leaves the questions of how long he leads, and who follows him, to the party. The NNP's experience shows the cost of leaving such matters late: whether the answer is a third campaign under Mr. Mitchell or a planned handover, the NDC should settle it publicly and well before 2030.

6. BRING IN NEW FACES BEFORE THEY ARE NEEDED

Long-serving governments age. The NDC should identify successors for members who may retire by 2030/31, introduce them early and give them public roles. The NNP's best result of 2026, in St. George North West, came from a succession announced ten months before polling day; its worst came where none had been planned.

7. KEEP THE BASE VOTING

The NDC's share of the electorate, 38.5 per cent, is higher than in 2022 but still well short of a majority of registered voters, and the register grew by more than 10,000 names in four years. A party seeking a third term needs a permanent registration and turnout operation, aimed at young voters and returning nationals, so that its majority does not depend on its opponents' supporters staying home.

BEYOND THE SHORELINE

A third term will not be decided only at home. Four issues that originate abroad, namely United States visa policy, the hospital known as Project Polaris, the citizenship-by-investment programme and the European Union's demand that it be wound down, will shape what the NDC can promise and pay for before 2030/31. Each could become an asset to the government or a liability, depending on how it is handled over the next four years.

WASHINGTON'S VISA SQUEEZE

In August 2025 the United States State Department announced visa restrictions on Grenadian government officials and their families over the Cuban medical programme, which Washington characterises as forced labour. Finance Minister Dennis Cornwall, who had told Parliament in March 2025 that he would give up his US visa rather than abandon Cuba, became the first Grenadian official to face direct action, while Foreign Minister Joseph Andall defended the medical brigade as indispensable to the health system. In September 2025, after talks in Havana, the government agreed to adjust the programme.

Ordinary Grenadians have since felt a wider tightening. Grenada was included in the suspension of US immigrant visa processing for 75 countries announced in January 2026, and from 2nd April 2026 Grenadian applicants for business and tourist visas may be required to post a bond of up to US$15,000, under a programme Washington says is aimed at reducing overstays. In September 2026 the State Department paused immigrant visa processing worldwide while consular staff were retrained.

For a party seeking a third term, the issue cuts both ways. Standing by Cuba resonates with part of the NDC's base and with the Caribbean tradition of non-alignment. Yet families with relatives in New York, students and small traders bear the cost of each new restriction, and the opposition will ask whether principle was worth the price. The NDC's task is to show that it can defend Grenada's

sovereignty while reopening the door: a negotiated end to the restrictions on officials, a credible plan to reduce overstays, and a sustained effort to have Grenada removed from the visa bond list.

PROJECT POLARIS: A HOSPITAL ON THE BALLOT

Project Polaris is the NDC's answer to its own 2022 promise of a new hospital. Construction of a 250-bed, climate-resilient teaching hospital at Hope Vale formally began on 27th March 2026, with an opening projected for 2029. Financing draws on the OPEC Fund, which agreed a US$60 million framework in December 2025, on Saudi and Kuwaiti development funds, and on a US$25 million government contribution.

The International Monetary Fund puts the expected cost at about US$250 million, roughly 17 per cent of Grenada's 2024 GDP. It has warned that the project's off-budget borrowing will delay the target of reducing public debt to 60 per cent of GDP by three years, to 2033, and has recommended that the fiscal rules be widened so that such borrowing is captured.

The timing makes Polaris the single most consequential project of a third-term campaign. If the hospital opens on schedule in 2029, the NDC will enter 2030/31 with a visible achievement on the edge of the capital. If it is late, over budget or financed on terms that voters come to doubt, it will become the opposition's strongest argument. Publishing regular reports on progress, cost and debt terms would be the government's best defence.

CITIZENSHIP BY INVESTMENT: THE BUDGET'S HIDDEN PILLAR

Much of the NDC's fiscal room has come from the citizenship-by-investment programme. Revenue reached exceptional levels in 2024 as a backlog of applications was cleared, then fell sharply in early 2025, a decline the Ministry of Finance said it had anticipated. In December 2025 Dr. Adrian Joseph, now the NNP's only member of parliament, estimated that investment migration revenue accounted for about 14 per cent of recurrent revenue, and urged that it be ring-fenced for capital investment and debt reduction rather than permanent spending.

That dependence is a third-term vulnerability. A revenue stream that has helped to fund hurricane recovery and the government's contribution to Polaris can shrink suddenly, through a fall in demand, a rule change in Washington or Brussels, or a scandal. Whichever party governs after 2030/31 will face the same question: what replaces the money if it falls away?

THE EUROPEAN ULTIMATUM

The largest external risk comes from Brussels. A revised EU visa suspension mechanism, in force since 30th December 2025, allows the operation of an investor citizenship scheme to count, in itself, as grounds for suspending visa-free travel to the Schengen area. On 25th June 2026 the European Commission wrote to Grenada and four other Eastern Caribbean states asking them to phase out their programmes by 1st June 2028 and to tighten their screening in the meantime. The Commission's next report under the mechanism, due in December 2026, will weigh their responses.

The heads of government of the five states replied in July 2026 with a joint statement committing them to coordinated diplomacy with the EU's institutions and member states. Any suspension would require a separate EU decision and is not automatic. The dilemma for the government is nonetheless stark: preserve a revenue stream on which the budget leans, or protect the visa-free access to Europe that Grenadians value. The Commission's deadline falls before the next election is due.

WHAT THE NDC MUST DO ABROAD

Four steps follow from this record. Negotiate with Washington to lift the restrictions on officials and to remove Grenada from the visa bond list, with an overstay-reduction plan to show for it. Publish Polaris's progress, costs and debt terms at regular intervals. Begin now to reduce the budget's reliance on citizenship-by-investment revenue, ring-fencing it for capital spending as Dr. Joseph proposed. And reach a settlement with the EU before June 2028 that preserves Schengen access, even if that means reforming or winding down the programme. Foreign policy seldom decides Grenadian elections; this time it may decide what a third-term government can afford to promise.

WHAT COULD STOP IT

The case against a third term is straightforward. Second-term governments lose their freshness, and third-term campaigns are fought on the record. Grenada's last three landslides were each followed by a sharp reversal within one or two elections. A reunited opposition would erase the NDC's lead in the Town immediately, and a modest recovery in NNP turnout would put the four front-line seats in play.

The NNP's supporters stayed home in 2026; for the most part, they did not become NDC voters. If the opposition settles its leadership, names its candidates early and reaches those 6,392 lost voters, the arithmetic of this volume changes quickly. A party that wins 14 seats can lose six of them in a single election, as the NDC itself demonstrated against the NNP in 2022.

WHAT IT MEANS FOR THE NNP

For the opposition, the lesson of this volume is the mirror image of the NDC's agenda. The NDC's majority is secure against a uniform swing, but not against a targeted one. The seats that matter are the same seven identified in Vol. 16, and the NDC knows it.

If the NDC gets these seven things right, it can make history in 2030/31. If it gets them wrong, it will join a long line of Grenadian governments that mistook a large majority for a permanent one.

THE NDC'S MAJORITY, SEAT BY SEAT

Constituency	NDC majority	NNP two-party %	Swing to flip
St. Andrew South East	162	47.9%	2.1
St. Andrew North East	320	46.0%	4.0
St. Mark	261	45.4%	4.6
St. John	573	43.6%	6.4
St. Andrew North West	785	39.4%	10.6
St. Patrick East	687	37.6%	12.4
Carriacou and Petite Martinique	976	37.2%	12.8
St. Andrew South West	1,094	35.5%	14.5
St. Patrick West	1,160	32.6%	17.4
St. George South East	1,294	32.2%	17.8
St. George North East	2,027	30.2%	19.8
Town of St. George	733*	29.7%	20.3*
St. David	3,180	28.7%	21.3
St. George South	2,792	28.5%	21.5

Majority and swing are against the NNP. Swing to flip: points of two-party swing from NDC to NNP needed to win the seat. *Town: against the NNP alone; NNP and DPM combined were 3 votes short of the NDC. The NNP holds St. George North West. 2026 figures provisional.

WHAT IT MEANS FOR 2030/31

1. On a uniform swing the NDC majority survives anything under 12.8 points.
2. Four seats would fall on a smaller swing than the NNP suffered in 2026.
3. The Town is safe for the NDC only while the opposition stays divided.
4. Fourteen MPs means more ambition than a cabinet can hold.
5. A second-term government is judged on delivery: publish the report card.
6. Settle the leadership and succession question well before 2030.
7. Build turnout: 35,571 registered voters did not vote in 2026.
8. Abroad: lift the visa restrictions and get Grenada off the US bond list.
9. Open Polaris on time, and settle CBI with the EU before June 2028.
10. For the NNP: the NDC majority is safe against a uniform swing, not a targeted one.

Sources: Parliamentary Elections Office live results, live.elections.gd (2026, provisional; all constituencies read 7 and 9 Nov 2026); Wikipedia (2022 and 2026 general elections; National Democratic Congress; New National Party); Jamaica Gleaner / CMC ('PM Mitchell leads NDC to historic victory', 6 Nov 2026); Caribbean Today (Prime Minister-elect promises to transform the country in 15 years, Jun 2022); Caribbean National Weekly (Mitchell on term limits); WIC News (2022 manifestos); NOW Grenada ('NDC performance in review', 3 Jul 2026); The Rio Times (NNP pledges, Nov 2026; Peter Wickham on the result, 6 Nov 2026); Nation News (2012–13 reports on the Thomas government). US State Department, via CMC, Jamaica Observer, Jamaica Gleaner, Caribbean Focus and Caribbean National Weekly (visa restrictions, Aug 2025 to Mar 2026); Searchlight (immigrant visa pause, Sep 2026); NOW Grenada and OPEC Fund (Project Polaris, Jan and Mar 2026); IMF 2025 Article IV staff report (Polaris cost and debt); NOW Grenada (Adrian Joseph on CBI revenue, Dec 2025); Visas News, IMI Daily and Government of Saint Lucia (EU visa suspension mechanism and heads' statement, Jun to Jul 2026). Swing and majority figures computed by the author from the published counts. Analysis by Greg Hosten, Vol. 17 of a weekly constituency series. Written in the style of a newspaper report; not a publication of any news organisation.